WORLD WAR II: THE PACIFIC



Kamikaze suicide attack
Smoke billows from US carrier *Belleau Wood* after an attack by a kamikaze pilot in October 1944. The battle of Leyte Gulf saw the first organized attacks by Japanese suicide planes—a tactic that became increasingly widespread in the closing stages of the Pacific War.

LAUNCHING A WAR in the Pacific was a desperate gamble by the Japanese. The temporary weakness of Britain, France, and the Netherlands—the colonial powers in southeast Asia—created an irresistible opportunity for Japan to seize control of the oil and other natural resources of British-ruled Malaya and the Dutch East Indies. But Japanese military leaders knew they would also have to fight the United States, with its vastly superior long-term warmaking potential. Admiral Isoroku Yamamoto, commander-in-chief of the Imperial Navy, proposed a surprise attack on the US naval base at Pearl Harbor, Hawaii. By crippling the US Pacific fleet, the Japanese would buy enough time to establish a defensive perimeter across the Pacific, ready to resist an eventual US counterattack. The raid on Pearl Harbor on December 7, 1941, initiated the most intensive large-scale naval conflict ever seen.

EARLY SUCCESSES

At the start of the Pacific War the Japanese and US fleets were quite evenly balanced, except in terms of carriers. Japan had more, and its carrier aircraft were the best in the world. For the first six months of the war Japanese forces ran amok. The Pearl Harbor raid subdued the US Navy briefly, and Britain's Royal Navy, committed to the war against Hitler's Germany, could offer little resistance. In early 1942 the formidable British base at Singapore fell to an attack from the land. Part of the Japanese fleet entered the Indian Ocean and there was nothing to stop it sailing up the Red Sea to the Suez Canal or attacking Iraq, a vital source of British oil supplies. But the Japanese never went further west than Sri Lanka. By May 1942 they were thoroughly occupied in the South Pacific, as the Americans fought back sooner than expected. US carrier aircraft checked Japanese carriers at the Coral Sea and then dealt them a severe blow at Midway—one from which the Imperial Japanese Navy never fully recovered.

Neither the Americans nor the Japanese shied away from a fight. Particularly fierce sea battles were fought around the island of Guadalcanal in the Solomon Islands, with heavy losses on both sides. The Americans benefited from superior naval intelligence—having broken the Japanese naval codes—but the Japanese proved

Desperate fighting
USS *Bunker Hill* burns after being hit by two kamikaze planes in the space of 30 seconds near Okinawa in 1945. Around 1,500 kamikaze planes were crashed into US ships or shot down during the Japanese defense of the island.



Next! Japan
A poster advertising bonds to help the US government finance the war in the Pacific and the drive on the Japanese home islands.